

Gaby Rivera

The Noise

There's been a thin shrill bugging my ears. Indefinitely.

I don't know when it'll stop. I don't know when it started. It's an evil noise, a static voice that unpleasantly scratches my skin. It feels like gravel whenever I rub it, and my protective layers feel as though they get weaker the more time passes on. The more harm is done. If I don't do anything about this noise, it'll permeate in my mind forever, and I fear I'll become mindless, controlled by an endless line of "bsst"s. I'll learn to understand its language, I'll find patterns and reasons for its speech.

My associates have told me it's a mere fly, but I think the creature appears to be more than that. I speculate it's smaller in courage but grandiose in covertness. I think its evil influence reproduces to taunt others, those without the means to find the source of the noise. Those that don't even know there's a noise. And those that are deemed stupid for exposing the noise.

The blind, the deaf, and the mute are the easiest to sway and manipulate. "Oh, that's not a real [REDACTED], it's a pre-recorded video." "Oh, that bite is the product of a wild insect, but it's not what you think." And oh, if you're mute, communicating your inconvenience would be an inconvenience to them. And by the time the transmission of information is successful, the noise has already flown away. Needless to say, your defenselessness and exposure attracts the noise.

Others may see it during or after the attack, but your pain will remain. If lucky, the noise could leave evidence behind. A bright red bite mark, popping, itching. It could be red, it could be subtle, bleeding, or infected. The attack could transcend deeper and further into your life, putting your health and safety at risk.

But this noise is special. This noise is guarded, protected by outside forces. If you try to search for a remedy, you will be persecuted by the noise again. And you don't want that. You don't want to deal with that.

You don't want to be oppressed and harassed by this noise, as its only desire is to force a reaction out of you. To scream, and swat it. To kill it.

It wants you to do exactly that. Ultimately, you will waste your time. And there will be no fruitful end goal for you.

Not only did you fail to punish your attacker, but it now knows of your intentions.

It will now contemplate on bringing backup, more of its kind to outnumber you.

The noise alone was exasperating already. You can't even start to fathom two gripping at your lasting patience. Maybe, at this point, it wouldn't be a matter of patience anymore but survival.

You've been considered a national threat, and it's the noise's duty to eliminate you.

All you ever wanted was a peaceful, soundless life.

You thought following the average, commonplace script was the most optimal way to achieve success and serenity. Focus on your studies, get employed, buy a house, and begin thinking about a family.

But the noise invited itself to your home. Your hard-earned property, worth years of tears, sweat and effort. It is now outside your door, not alone. The noise has found you. Your ear was never alone. The school bell followed you, the super-market scanner followed you, the construction site beeping followed you; everywhere you went and pursued your dreams and goals, you made a pledge to be civil, educated, and disciplined. To abide by the law and speak no ill of those that have held power and confinement over your life.

Then you did the unforgivable. The *unthinkable*. And rebelled against the noise. The noise bothered you at first, but then it disturbed you. It was an ugly buzzing spitting nonsense and unforgivings. It sucked your blood, drained your income and integrity when you least expected it.

It was an exchange, a gift for your obedience. But then you challenged it. You spoke truths and insults you shouldn't have confessed. You warned your family and friends of this epidemic, of the threat and fear that snuck towards you and, insidiously, towards everyone in your vicinity. Everyone you love. Stuck in this bubble of a country.

This country has always been overrun by swamps with similar species and motives. Masses that pass on the same beliefs and duties onto their children, their successors, who will terrify the rest again. A never-ending cycle.

Their voices will become yours, and your mind, their resolve.

Your body lays sprawled, bloodied on the floor with your joints detached, twisted into spider-like legs. No one will recognize you. You've become disfigured. Even now, your mouth utters the awful shrill. Indefinitely.